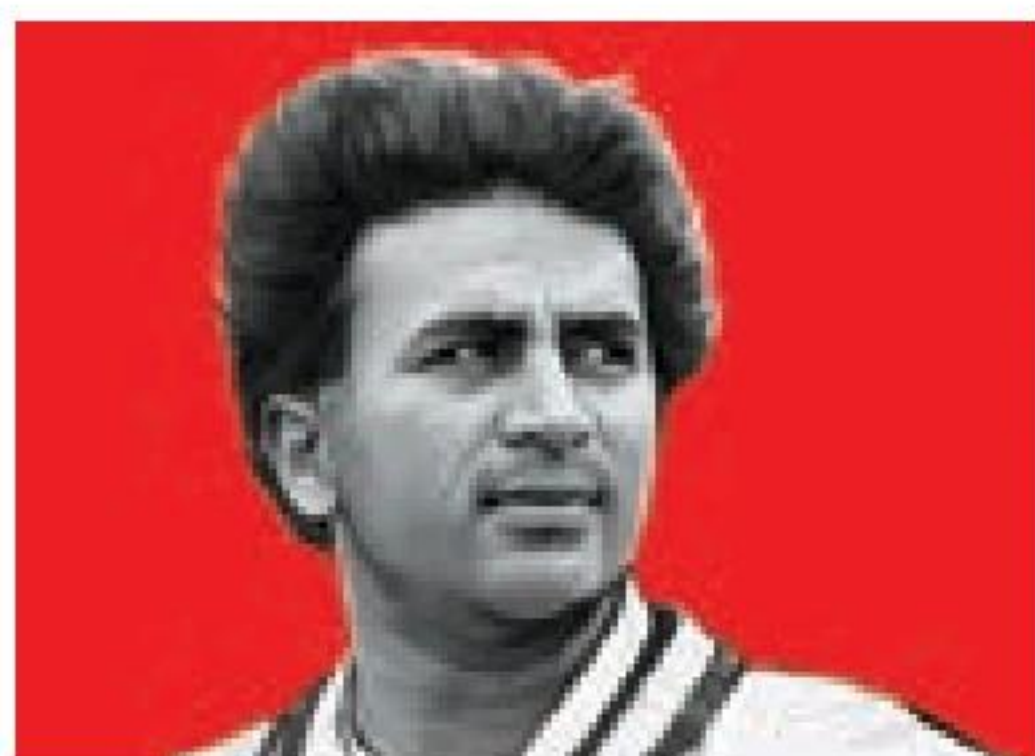




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



IF INDIAN CRICKET RULES THE WORLD TODAY, THE SEED FOR THAT WAS SOWN BY THAT INCREDIBLE WIN IN 1983

The **World Cup win** changed the outlook not only of Indian cricket, its players and its administrators, but also of the rest of the cricketing world towards it.

The 1983 World Cup-winning team just received a terrific welcome and felicitation in Singapore. The visit, facilitated by the Mariners Club, gave the team, who are not getting any younger and, by the looks of some, not getting any older either, a chance to see the passion for cricket in Singapore. At the Singapore Indian Association ground, there were so many young kids that, if the Singapore Cricket Association takes its mandate of developing cricket in the island nation seriously, a good team could emerge in the not-too-distant future. **Not just the boys but the girls too were impressive, and the competitiveness was most refreshing.** Cricket is not the main sport there, and so a real effort needs to be made to tap into this enthusiasm and develop the game at the grassroots level. While neighbouring Malaysia has seemingly made better progress in the game, Singapore is still to catch up, despite having administrators at the highest echelons of the ICC.

The Mariners, who hosted the team, went

out of their way to look after us, and big thanks to Abhijit Dutta, Rajan Mathur and Subir Ghatak, to name just three of the many Mariners who made untiring efforts to cater to the team's every need. **Also, a big sorry to all the kids who came there and couldn't get autographs or photographs because the tournament's prize distribution was going on and so we couldn't step off the stage.** We were simply overwhelmed by the reception and the affection shown at the ground as well as at the gala dinner the previous evening. To have this kind of affection more than 43 years after the team made history is a blessing, pure and simple.

I mentioned this event simply to underscore how that win changed the outlook not only of Indian cricket, its players and its administrators, but also of the rest of the cricketing world towards Indian cricket. There was a newfound confidence to look everybody in the eye and a spring in the step towards more glory in the future. If Indian cricket rules the world today, much to the chagrin of the old powers, the seed for that was sown by that